

York & the Minster - Kids

UK Family Tour

York: Walk on Top of a City's Armor

York is a city you can walk around ON TOP of — it still has its medieval walls, over three kilometers of them, the longest town walls in England, and walking them is free. But the story starts even earlier: Roman soldiers founded this city in the year 71 and called it Eboracum. It became so important that Roman emperors ruled the whole empire from here. Two emperors even died in York, and in the year 306, right where the Minster now stands, soldiers lifted a young man onto their shields and proclaimed him emperor: Constantine the Great — the emperor who went on to make Christianity legal across the Roman world and to found Constantinople. One of history's most important people got his job in York. Look for his statue lounging outside the Minster. As you walk the walls, you'll pass through fortified gates called "bars" — which is confusing, because in York, a bar is a gate and a gate is a street. Streets here are called "gates" — Stonegate, Petergate, Coppergate — from the Viking word "gata," meaning street. So in York: gates are streets, bars are gates, and the pubs are... also bars. Locals enjoy watching visitors work this out.

The Legion That Vanished

When the Romans built York, they didn't build a town first. They built an army base. A legionary fortress was the home of a whole legion, around five thousand highly trained soldiers, and the men who raised York's first walls and streets in the year seventy-one belonged to the Ninth Legion. Imagine the noise of it: thousands of soldiers drilling, blacksmiths hammering, carts rolling in through the gates, and, believe it or not, a giant heated bath, because Roman soldiers loved a good soak after a hard day. You can still stand right over a piece of that bathhouse today, underneath a pub in the middle of York that is actually called the Roman Bath. Now here comes the mystery, and it's a real one. The Ninth Legion was famous and tough. They were here, in York, building in solid stone. The very last certain trace of them anywhere in the world is a slab they carved to celebrate finishing a great gateway, around the year one hundred and eight. You can go and see that exact stone in the Yorkshire Museum, just a short walk away. And then, nothing. The Ninth Legion simply drops out of history. No battle report, no farewell, no record of where five thousand men went. For hundreds of years people have asked the same question you're probably asking right now: what happened to them? One famous story says they marched north into the wild lands beyond Scotland to fight fierce tribes, and were wiped out, every last one, and never came back. That's the tale in a well-known adventure book called *The Eagle of the Ninth*. But other experts think the legion was quietly shipped off to a far corner of the empire, thousands of miles away, and destroyed in some battle there instead. The honest answer is that nobody knows for sure. A whole army, thousands of soldiers, and history lost them. What we do know is that a new legion, the Sixth, marched into York to take their place, and stayed for hundreds of years. So as you walk these streets, remember you're treading the same ground as a legion that vanished, leaving behind their walls, their bathhouse, and one carved stone that seems to say: we were here. And then a question with no answer.

The Wooden Castle and the Saddest Night

Look for the grassy hill in the middle of York with a stone tower crouched on top, shaped a little like a four-leaf clover. That's Clifford's Tower, and its hill has a long and dramatic story. The hill itself is your first clue, because it isn't natural. When the Normans conquered England, their leader William marched north to control this rebellious city, and around the year ten sixty-eight his men piled up this enormous mound of earth by hand and built a wooden castle on top to keep watch over York. Wooden castles, though, have one big weakness. They burn. And the saddest part of this hill's story is about fire. In the year eleven ninety, something terrible happened here. A small community of Jewish families lived in York, under the special protection of the king. But an angry mob turned on them, partly because some of the attackers owed them money and wanted their debts to simply disappear. The families fled up this very hill and locked themselves inside the wooden tower for safety. Trapped, surrounded, with no way out, around one hundred and fifty people died on the night before an important holy day, and the wooden tower burned to the ground. It's not a happy story, but it's an important one, and York remembers it. There's a stone plaque at the foot of the mound so that the people who died here are never forgotten. The tower you see now came later. A king named Henry the Third rebuilt it in stone, in that unusual clover shape, so it could never burn so easily again. Except, well, it sort of did. In the year sixteen eighty-four a great explosion and fire gutted the inside, which is why the tower today is really a mighty stone shell with no roof, open to the sky. Climb up the steps if you can, walk around the top of the walls, and you'll get one of the best views in the whole city, right across the rooftops to the towers of the Minster. One small hill, and standing on it you've touched the Normans, a king, a tragedy, an explosion, and the finest photo spot in York.

Heads on Spikes and a Falling Iron Gate

As you walk the walls, you'll come to the great stone gateways called bars, and each one was a machine for keeping enemies out. Slow down at them, because they are full of nasty, brilliant tricks. Start with the scariest one. The grandest gate is called Micklegate Bar, the gate where kings and queens rode into the city in all their finery. But it was also the gate where they stuck the heads of traitors. Yes, real human heads, chopped off and jammed onto spikes on top of the gate, left there for everyone to see as a warning of what happens if you cross the king. The most famous head of all belonged to a duke named Richard of York, and his enemies thought it was funny to jam a crown made of paper onto his dead head, because he had wanted to be king and never made it. Imagine walking under that on your way to market. For hundreds of years, that was normal in York.

Now find Monk Bar, the tallest gate of them all, four whole storeys high. Look up under the archway as you pass through and hunt for a heavy iron grille, like a giant metal comb with spikes along the bottom. That's a portcullis, and it could come crashing straight down to slam the gate shut in a heartbeat. Monk Bar is the only gate in York that still has one that actually works, and it was last dropped for real not that long ago. Then look for the "murder holes," small openings in the stone above the archway. If enemies were trapped underneath, the soldiers up top could drop horrible things down through those holes onto their heads. You can guess the sort of things.

There's more. At a gate called Walmgate Bar, there's a walled stone yard sticking out in front of it, called a barbican. It was a trap. Attackers who broke through the first gate found themselves stuck in a narrow pen with soldiers firing down at them from every side, before they even reached the real door. It's the only gate in all of England that still has one. And at Bootham Bar, in the old days, a stranger who wanted to come into York had to bang a special door knocker and actually ask the Lord Mayor for permission to enter the city. So the next time someone at home tells you to knock before you come in, you can tell them the people of York have been doing exactly that for about seven hundred years. Four gates, four tricks: heads on spikes, a crashing iron gate, murder holes, and a trap made of stone. Find them all as you walk.

The Shambles: The Wonkiest Street in Britain

Find the Shambles — a narrow, crooked street where the old buildings lean so far toward each other that neighbors in the top floors could reach across and shake hands. It's often called the best-preserved medieval street in Europe, and it looks so magical that many people believe it inspired Diagon Alley in the Harry Potter films — the film-makers never confirmed it, but the street is now full of wizard shops that are very happy for you to believe it. Here's the un-magical truth about why it looks this way: the Shambles was the street of the butchers. The word "shambles" originally meant the benches where meat was displayed — you can still see wide wooden shelf-sills under some windows, which were the meat counters. The buildings lean inward on purpose: the overhanging upper floors kept the sun off the meat hanging below. There were about twenty-five butcher shops here, and everything you'd rather not think about ran down the channel in the middle of the street. That's why "a shambles" came to mean a total mess — the word you use when your room is a disaster comes from this exact street. Today it smells considerably better: mostly fudge.

The Ghost Soldiers in the Cellar

Here's one of the most famous ghost stories in all of England, and the strangest part is what came afterwards. Near the Minster stands an old house called the Treasurer's House. The story goes that back in nineteen fifty-three, a young man named Harry Martindale, just eighteen years old, was working alone down in the cellar, fixing pipes, standing near the top of a ladder. Suddenly he heard a sound: a single note, like a trumpet, blown over and over, growing louder. And then, out of the solid stone wall, a soldier stepped into the cellar. Behind him came a great tired carthorse, and then rows and rows of Roman soldiers, marching, looking exhausted and filthy, carrying round shields and spears. Harry was so terrified he tumbled off his ladder and pressed himself into a corner. But here's the eerie detail that makes people believe him. He could only see the soldiers from the knees up. Their feet were hidden, as if they were walking on a road lower than the cellar floor. Harry told this story for the rest of his life, always exactly the same way, and he never once accepted money to tell it. Now for the part that gives people goosebumps. Years later, archaeologists dug beneath that very house, and what did they find? A real Roman road, a proper stone highway, running right where Harry said the soldiers walked, at exactly the level of their hidden feet. Even stranger, the odd round shields Harry described, which experts first said were wrong for Roman soldiers, turned out to match soldiers who really were stationed in York much later in Roman times. How could a young plumber who knew almost nothing about Roman history describe all that correctly? Nobody can explain it. Maybe he saw ghosts. Maybe there's another answer we simply haven't thought of yet. But if you visit the Treasurer's House, remember that somewhere beneath your feet runs an ancient road, and once, so the story goes, a whole column of soldiers came marching down it, straight out of the wall. Listen for a trumpet.

The Boy from York Who Tried to Blow Up Parliament

Every year on the fifth of November, all across Britain, the sky fills with fireworks and people light huge bonfires. And it all began with a boy from York. His name was Guy Fawkes, and he was born right here in the year fifteen seventy, in a house on a street called Stonegate, just around the corner from the Minster. When he was only a few days old, he was carried into the little church that still stands right beside the great cathedral, called Saint Michael le Belfrey, and baptised there. You can walk past both spots today. As a boy, Guy went to school in York, and by all accounts he was clever and serious. But he grew up in dangerous times, when people could be punished for the way they prayed, and Guy came to believe the government was treating people like him cruelly. So he joined a daring and dangerous plot. In

the year sixteen hundred and five, he and a group of others hid dozens of barrels of gunpowder in a cellar right underneath the Houses of Parliament in London, planning to blow the whole building sky-high in one enormous explosion. But the plot was discovered at the very last minute. Guards crept down into the cellar in the dark, and there they found Guy Fawkes, standing guard over the barrels, ready to light the fuse. The plot failed completely. And that is why, every November, people light bonfires and set off fireworks, remembering the night the great explosion did not happen. Sometimes they even burn a straw figure called a guy, named after him. But here's a lovely York twist. It's said that Guy's very own old school in York, which is still open today, politely refuses to burn a guy on Bonfire Night, out of respect for a boy who once sat in its classrooms. So the most famous troublemaker in British history was a York schoolboy, and the whole country lights up the sky because of him. Not bad, or perhaps not good, for a lad from Stonegate.

Secret Passages: The Snickelways

Here is a game to play as you wander York, and it might be the best one in the whole city. All around the old streets, hidden between the shops and the houses, are tiny secret passageways, so narrow you sometimes have to turn sideways to squeeze through. You could walk past the entrance a hundred times and never notice it, just a slot in the wall, a dark little gap, and then suddenly it opens out onto a completely different street. There are around fifty of them threaded through the old part of the city, some of them six or seven hundred years old, worn smooth by centuries of shoulders and boots. People used them as shortcuts to nip from street to street, and you can still use them for exactly the same thing today. Duck into one. See where it spits you out.

These passages have a wonderful name: snickelways. And here's a fun secret about the word. It's not ancient at all. A man named Mark Jones simply made it up in nineteen eighty three, when he wrote a little book about them, by squashing together three older words that all mean a narrow passage. He took snicket, and ginnel, and alleyway, and mashed them into snickelway. The people of York liked it so much that everyone just started using it, as if it had always been there. So it's a brand new word for some very old passages.

While you're hunting them, keep your eyes open for the strangest street sign in York. There's a tiny street, barely longer than a bus, with the longest and silliest name in the whole city. It's called Whip Ma Whop Ma Gate. Nobody is completely sure what it means, though it may once have been a rude sort of joke, and it has the funny distinction of being the shortest street in York with the longest name. There's another passage that used to be called Mad Alice Lane, named after a woman who is said to have lived there long ago, though as with a lot of York's spookiest tales, it's hard to know how much is true. So here is your mission for the Shambles and the streets around it. Don't just walk down the big streets like everyone else. Find the hidden slots in the walls, squeeze through, and pop out somewhere new, like you've found a secret level in a game. The whole old city is riddled with them, and most grown ups walk straight past without ever noticing they're there.

The Brave Woman at Number Thirty-Five

As you walk down the Shambles, look for a doorway with a little quiet room inside it, almost like a tiny chapel, tucked among all the fudge shops and wizard shops. It's there to remember a very brave woman who lived on this street more than four hundred years ago, and her name was Margaret Clitherow. To understand her, you need to know one strange and difficult thing about those times. Back then, in England, the government told everybody exactly how they were allowed to pray and which church they had to go to. If you believed something different, you could be punished for it, even thrown in prison. It's hard to imagine now, being told you're not allowed to choose what you believe, but that was the law, and people took it deadly seriously.

Margaret was married to a butcher on the Shambles, so she lived right here among the meat hooks and the busy stalls. But Margaret had chosen a different faith from the one the government demanded, and she refused to give it up. More than that, she was brave enough to help others who shared her beliefs. She hid them in her house. She had a secret hiding place built, a small concealed spot where a person could crouch out of sight when the king's men came searching, and she quietly gave shelter to people who would have been arrested if they'd been found. Imagine keeping a secret that big, that dangerous, in a crowded little house on a busy street, with soldiers who might knock on your door at any moment.

In the end, Margaret was caught, in the year fifteen eighty-six. And here is the part that shows how remarkable she was. When she was put on trial, she chose to stay silent and not argue her case, on purpose, because if there had been a proper trial, her own children might have been forced to stand up and speak against her, and she could not bear to put them through that. She protected her children right to the very end, and she was punished with her life for what she believed. Today many people think of her as a hero and a saint, and that little shrine on the Shambles is where they remember her. So as you pass the sweet shops and the crowds, just pause for a second at that quiet doorway. Somewhere on this exact wonky, magical street once lived a butcher's wife who was braver than almost anyone, who kept an enormous secret, and who loved her children so much that she stayed silent to keep them safe.

York Minster: 250 Years of Building

York Minster is one of the biggest cathedrals in Europe — so big it took two hundred and fifty years to build, from 1220 to 1472. Think about that: the workers who started it knew they'd never see it finished. Neither would their kids. Or their grandkids. Stonemasons spent whole lifetimes carving, and a team of masons still works here today, in the same stoneyard, replacing worn stones with new hand-carved ones — the building has basically never stopped being built. Inside, look east for the Great East Window: the largest single medieval stained-glass window in the world, roughly the size of a tennis court, made by one master glazier, John Thornton, in just three years starting in 1405. It tells the story of the beginning and end of the world in over three hundred glass panels. Then find the Rose Window, and the Five Sisters — five tall grey-green windows made of thirteenth-century grisaille glass. Now the survival story: this glass has escaped fire after fire, including a huge one in 1984 when lightning struck the roof. Firefighters deliberately collapsed the burning roof to save the rest — and the Rose Window cracked into forty thousand pieces but held together, and was painstakingly repaired. Your ticket lets you return free for a year. The Minster plays the long game.

Monsters and a Clock for the Stars

The Minster is enormous, but the real fun is in the small things hiding high above your head, so keep looking up. First, hunt for the dragon. High on a wall in the long main hall of the cathedral juts a real wooden dragon's head, painted gold, sticking straight out into the air. Nobody today knows exactly why it's there, but the cleverest guess is that it was once a kind of crane, a lifting arm. People think a chain ran through a hole in the dragon's head, so the monks could raise and lower a heavy wooden lid that covered the font, the special stone basin where babies were baptised. A dragon that was really a machine. Next, go on a face hunt. Carved all around the stone, if you search, you'll find funny and fierce little faces. Some are grotesques, pulling silly or scary expressions to make you look twice. Others are green men, strange faces with leaves and vines sprouting right out of their mouths and noses, a mysterious carving found in old churches all over the country, and no one is completely sure what they mean. Then find something that looks like a clock but really isn't about telling the time at all. It's the astronomical clock, and instead of hours and minutes it shows the sun and the stars, drawn the way a pilot would see them looking out of a plane flying high over York. Why a pilot? Because this beautiful clock is a memorial. It was made to remember around eighteen thousand airmen, from this part of England, who flew away in the Second World War and never came home. Beneath it rests a book with their names written inside, and every single day someone gently turns a page. So in one great building you can find a dragon that was really a machine, faces with leaves growing out of them, and a clock that maps the sky for pilots who are gone. The Minster looks solemn and still, but it is actually full of secrets and surprises, hiding in plain sight, waiting for the family that bothers to look up and really see them.

The Night the Minster Caught Fire

On a stormy July night in nineteen eighty-four, disaster struck the Minster. A thunderstorm rolled over York in the small hours of the morning, lightning cracked down, and the roof of one huge arm of the cathedral, the south transept, burst into flames. The fire roared for hours in the darkness. The firefighters made an incredibly brave and painful decision: they deliberately pulled the burning roof down, collapsing it on purpose, because if they hadn't, the flames would have spread and might have destroyed far more of the ancient building. By morning the south transept was open to the sky, blackened and smoking. But here is where the story turns wonderful. When it was time to rebuild the ceiling high above, the builders needed new roof bosses. A boss is a carved knot of wood or stone, round like a badge, set at the exact

spot where the ribs of the ceiling cross each other, and the Minster's ceiling has dozens of them. Six of the old ones were gone. So the television programme Blue Peter set the children of Britain a challenge: design a new roof boss showing something important that happened in the twentieth century. Over thirty thousand children sent in drawings. Six winners were chosen, and their designs were carved and lifted up into the brand-new ceiling, where they still are today. So next time you're inside, tilt your head back and search the south transept roof. Among all the medieval saints and angels carved by people who lived six hundred years ago, you'll spot an astronaut walking on the Moon, because a child drew it. You'll find the raising of the Mary Rose, King Henry the Eighth's great warship, lifted from the bottom of the sea. There's a whale, and a deep-sea diver, all imagined by children not much older than you. Think about that. A cathedral that took two hundred and fifty years to build, that survived a terrible fire, now carries pictures dreamed up by ordinary kids, right up there among the treasures, meant to last for hundreds of years. Somewhere in England a grown-up today can point up at that Moon and say, I drew that when I was your age.

The Room with No Middle, and a Viking's Horn

Two last treasures before you go, and they're easy to miss. First, find the Chapter House. It's a beautiful room, and it has eight sides, like a giant stone drum, with a wide painted ceiling arching overhead. Now look for the pillar in the middle holding that heavy roof up. Go on, look. There isn't one. That's the trick, and it amazed people when it was built in the twelve eighties. Back then, a stone ceiling this wide would normally have needed a thick column planted right in the centre. But the medieval carpenters were so daring and so skilled that they built the whole roof out of wood, cleverly balanced so it holds itself up with nothing in the middle at all. The room is so proud of itself that there's an old saying carved inside, boasting that just as the rose is the best of all flowers, this is the best of all rooms. Second, go down into the Undercroft, the museum beneath the cathedral, and find the Horn of Ulf. It's a long curved horn, and it was carved from a real elephant's tusk almost a thousand years ago, far away in Italy, before it travelled all the way here to York. But it isn't just for decoration. A rich lord named Ulf, whose family were descended from Vikings, wanted to give his lands to the Minster. Today you'd sign papers. Back then, Ulf simply walked into the cathedral and handed over this magnificent horn instead, and everyone agreed the horn itself was the proof, as good as any signature. A drinking horn that stands for a whole estate of land. So there's your challenge for the Minster: find the room with no middle, and the elephant-tusk horn that once bought a piece of England. Do that, and you'll have seen two things that most visitors walk straight past without ever knowing they were there.

The Biggest Picture in the World

Go and stand right at the far east end of the Minster, the end furthest from the doors, and look up at the enormous window there. It's called the Great East Window, and it is about the size of a whole tennis court standing on its end, made of hundreds and hundreds of little pieces of coloured glass. But here's the thing most people don't realise: it isn't just a pretty pattern. It's a picture. In fact it's a giant comic strip made of glass, and it tells one enormous story, the whole history of the world from the very beginning all the way to the very end.

Read it like a comic, from the top. Right up at the top, so high you can barely see, is the beginning of everything, the world being made. Then the huge middle part, the bit your eyes land on, shows the end of the world, and this is where it gets wild. A man who lived long ago wrote down a dream about how the world would end, full of monsters and angels and disasters, and the artist put the whole thing into glass. So if you look closely you can spot a dragon with seven heads, angels blowing trumpets, a beast crawling up out of the sea, and stars falling out of the sky. It might be the biggest picture of the end of the world anywhere on the planet. The man who made it was a master glassmaker called John Thornton, and he finished the whole thing in only three years, more than six hundred years ago.

Now for the part that will make your jaw drop. A few years ago, the whole window was in trouble. The glass was crumbling and the pictures were disappearing under six hundred years of dirt. So a team of experts did something almost unbelievable. They took the entire window apart, every single one of its three hundred and eleven panels, lifted them all out, and cleaned and mended each one by hand, one at a time. People called it the biggest jigsaw puzzle in England. It took them ten whole years, and it cost millions and millions of pounds. Then they fitted every piece carefully back, and even put a second, invisible sheet of clear glass on the outside to protect it from the rain forever. So when you look up at that window glowing in front of you, remember two people. Remember John Thornton, who imagined the end of the world and made it out of glass six hundred years ago. And remember the modern team who took his masterpiece to pieces, cleaned every scrap of it, and put it back together, so that you could stand here today and see it shine.

The Cathedral That Was Falling Down

Here's a secret about this gigantic, solid looking cathedral: about sixty years ago, it was quietly falling down, and hardly anyone knew. Stand underneath the very middle of the Minster, right where the four great arms of the building meet, and look straight up at the huge tower rising above you. That tower is the heaviest part of the whole cathedral, thousands and thousands of tonnes of stone, and back in the nineteen sixties, experts made a frightening discovery. It was sinking. The stone deep underground that was holding it all up was crumbling, and cracks were creeping through the walls. If nobody did anything, that gigantic tower could come crashing down. On the television, they even made a programme called, more or less, York Minster is falling down.

So they had to save it, and the way they did it is brilliant. Engineers dug down underneath the cathedral, right below the floor you're standing on, and built a hidden skeleton of steel and concrete deep in the ground to grip the old foundations and hold the whole tower up. You can't see any of it. It's buried beneath your feet, silently doing its job this very second, which is the only reason the tower above your head is still standing. But now comes the amazing surprise, the treasure they never expected to find. As the engineers dug down into the ground, they broke through into something incredible. Down there in the dark, they found the buried walls of the Roman army fort, the headquarters of the Roman soldiers, still standing exactly where the Romans had left them more than one thousand five hundred years ago. The cathedral had been built right on top of the Roman commander's own building, without anyone alive knowing it was there.

They were so amazed that instead of covering it all back up, they turned the hole into a museum called the Undercroft, and you can walk down into it. When you do, look carefully, because in the space of a few steps you go past Roman stone at the bottom, then the walls the Normans built on top of that, and then the modern concrete that's holding everything up, all stacked one on top of the other like the layers of a cake. It's like a time machine you climb down into. So this enormous cathedral has a double secret. It was once falling down and was rescued by a hidden metal skeleton buried in the earth, and while they were saving it, they accidentally discovered a lost Roman fort sleeping right underneath. Go down the steps and stand among it. You'll be standing in about two thousand years of history, all at once.

The War of the Flowers

Once, long ago, England had a war that was named after flowers. It sounds gentle and pretty, doesn't it, a war of flowers? It was not. It was one of the most dangerous times in all of English history, when the royal family split into two sides and fought each other for the crown, on and off, for about thirty years. And each side chose a flower as its badge, the way football teams have their colours. One side was called the House of Lancaster, and their badge was a red rose. The other side was called the House of York, this very city's own family, and their badge was a white rose. We call the whole struggle the Wars of the Roses, red rose against white rose, and cousins fought cousins in muddy fields all across the country.

Now, York picked the white rose, and to this very day the whole county of Yorkshire still wears it proudly. You'll see white roses everywhere, on flags, on caps, on badges. It's the flower of this place. And the king caught up most tightly in all this was named Richard the Third. Before he was king, he lived in the north and he loved this city, and this city loved him right back. So when Richard was killed in a great battle far to the south, defeated by an enemy who then took the crown for himself, the people of York were heartbroken. And they did a very brave thing. They wrote down in the city's own record book that their king had been, in their words, piteously slain and murdered, to the great heaviness of this city. Great heaviness means enormous sadness. That was daring, because the new king was watching, and he did not want anyone being sad about the man he'd just beaten. But York wrote down its grief anyway. That's how much this city loved him.

So how do you end a thirty year war between two families? In the end, they did it not with a battle but with a wedding. A man from the red rose side married a woman from the white rose side, and the two families became one at last. And to celebrate, someone had a clever idea. They took the red rose and the white rose and combined them into a brand new flower, a single rose with red petals on the outside and white petals inside. It's called the Tudor rose, and once you know it, you'll spot it carved all over old English buildings. Look for it here in York too. There's even a giant round window high up inside the Minster, called the Rose Window, that celebrates that very wedding, the moment the red rose and the white rose finally stopped fighting and joined together into one. A war named after flowers, ended by a flower. Keep your eyes peeled for roses all day. Every one is telling you this story.

Dick Turpin: The Ride That Never Happened

Long ago, England was full of robbers called highwaymen, who rode fast horses and lay in wait on the lonely roads at night. When a carriage came rattling by, a highwayman would gallop out of the shadows, point a pistol, and shout the famous words, "Stand and deliver! Your money or your life!" And the most famous highwayman of them all is a man named Dick Turpin, whose story ends right here in York. But here's the surprise. The most famous thing about Dick Turpin never actually happened.

The legend goes like this. One night, so the story says, Dick Turpin leapt onto his beautiful, brave horse Black Bess and galloped all the way from London to York in a single night, two hundred miles without stopping, riding so hard and so fast that poor Black Bess ran her heart out and dropped down dead the moment they arrived. It's a thrilling story. Children have loved it for almost two hundred years. And it is completely made up. A writer simply invented the whole thing for an exciting adventure book, about a hundred years after the real Turpin had died. There was no midnight ride. There was no horse called Black Bess. None of it is true. It's a brilliant example of how a made up story can become so famous that people start to believe it really happened.

So who was the real Dick Turpin? Well, he was not a dashing hero at all. He was a butcher's son who turned into a nasty criminal, a robber and a horse thief who even shot a man. He ran away to Yorkshire

and hid here under a false name, pretending to be an honest horse dealer, while secretly stealing the horses he was selling. And do you know the silly little thing that finally caught him? While he was locked up, he wrote a letter to his brother in law asking for help. But the brother in law wouldn't pay the cost of the letter, so it sat in the post office, until a man who had once taught Dick Turpin to write as a boy recognised his handwriting on the envelope. Caught out by his own scribble! He was put on trial here in York, found guilty of stealing horses, and in the year seventeen thirty nine he was hanged, out on the ground where the racecourse is today. Right at the end, he tried to look grand, buying smart new clothes and even paying five strangers to walk behind him and cry, as if he were someone important. So remember the real story. The daring midnight ride is a fairy tale someone invented. The true Dick Turpin was a horse thief, undone by his own handwriting, right here in the city of York.